

Windows Tango to be easy on RAM

Windows along with Nokia is gearing up to penetrate the mid-tier segment
<http://bit.ly/wiuJ8b>

Xbox coming in 2013?

Xbox is reportedly poised to be released in late 2013 with Radeon 6000 GPU
<http://bit.ly/yXbYmp>

MFDs below Rs. 20,000

HOW WE TESTED?

All the multi-functional devices that we got were tested on our standard MFD test bench consisting of an Intel Core i7 2600K 3.4 GHz CPU, 2 x 4GB of Kingston HyperX DDR3 RAM, ZOTAC GTX 450 GPU, Velociraptor 600GB @ 10,000RPM hard-drive and a Z68 Extreme3 Gen3 motherboard. Considering the fact that not many home and SoHo users buy MFDs over ₹ 20,000, we only called for MFDs below this price.

Before testing the MFDs we ran a few dry runs so as to get them heated up. We used standard A4 size paper for normal print and copy tests, and glossy paper for photo prints. We ran MFD tests such as text printing, mixed document printing, photo printing, copying, scanning, ADF printing and sharpness testing. In the text-only document test we checked clarity of the smallest and largest fonts and rated them on three aspects - edges clarity (Serif fonts), blotting and cracks. In the mixed document, tests we tested the prints against each other for clarity of text, merging colours, changing gradations of colours and white to black progressions. In our photo test, we printed an A4 size test photo, and checked for the sharpness levels, colour output and also looked for flaws such as merging of colours or grain. We considered four aspects where we could rate the quality print-out and then the final quality score was an average of all the individual test scores.

For the copy tests, we compared the output to the source and checked for noise, change in colour level, clarity, etc. The new addition this time around was a dedicated test for checking the sharpness of the print. We also checked scanning speeds and quality in all the MFDs. Each test was timed and scored accordingly.

We also gave importance to an MFD's features - the more the features the better the MFD scored. We also rated the MFDs for their ease of use - setting them up, installation of cartridges, and their software interface. The build quality of the MFDs was also given importance and were given scores accordingly. Although most MFDs have become cheaper to buy, they still have high running costs, considering this fact we also calculated the total cost of ownership (TCO) and gave it a sizable weightage. For calculating the TCO, we assumed that the average life of an MFD in Home and SoHo condition would be 3 years and prints taken in a year would be approximately 1,000 for an inkjet MFD and 2000 for a laser MFD and then calculated the cost of owning the MFD for that long. We also assumed that one would take a Black and White print 60 per cent of the time and a colour print 40 per cent of the time. Keeping this in mind we calculated the cost of the MFD, cost of cartridges and thus cost per print. The TOC index we got was considered in the overall score of the MFD.

play along with the necessary physical buttons.

The HP Photosmart 6510, though not truly a compact MFD, sports a good design. Its glossy-cum-matte black body ensured that the HP MFD stood out from the rest. Its control panel, which is a massive 3.45-inch touchscreen, is hugely convenient. The HP 6510 has no physical buttons, except a power on switch. Everything else is touch-sensitive.

Build

The only MFD that delivers excellent build quality is the Epson K300. While most MFDs struggled with flimsy input and output trays and scanner flaps, the K300 had the sturdiest build among them all. Unfortunately, the same can't be said of the Epson K200, which had the worst build among the lot - the input tray was so flimsy that it was in constant danger of getting damaged.

The Epson WP-4511 is the bulkiest and biggest MFD of the lot. We expected it to have the best build, but to our disappointment it was found to be lacking in certain areas. The input tray was extremely well made with least amount of flim-

were inkjet MFDs. Let's look at each category.

Inkjet MFDs

We received two colour inkjet MFDs from Brother (MFC-J430W and MFC-J625DW) two mono inkjet MFDs from Epson (K200 and K300), two colour inkjet MFDs from Epson (Me Office 535 and WorkForce Pro-4511) and finally one colour inkjet MFD from HP (Photosmart 6510).

Design

Four MFDs made a mark in this category for their uber-compact design. The two Brother MFDs, MFC-J430W and MFC-J625DW, have the best design among these four MFDs. Both the MFDs have a black body with a glossy Automatic Docu-

ment Feeder (ADF) flap and a prominent black bezel for the display screen. This design is an exciting break from the vanilla, off-white, corporate looking MFDs.

The other two MFDs with a compact design come from Epson, the Epson ME Office 535 and Epson K200. The Epson K200 doesn't have an awe-inspiring design but what makes it a hit is the no-nonsense simplistic design - even a layman would be able to set it up. The MFD, however, has a very boring and drab look with the standard off-white body. The Epson K200's control panel doesn't have too many buttons or a screen, making you dependent on a PC to make all the setting changes or to give the

scan commands. On the other hand, the Epson ME Office 535 is a sexy looking MFD with a completely black body. The control panel on the ME Office 535 adds a small colour dis-



Brother MFC-J625DW: The best performer of the test